have dominated the faith. But in its origins, the expression refers to the ideal of attaining the Brahman, the Universal Spirit that suffuses the cosmos. Many use the Sanskrit-Hindi phrase, 'Sanatana Dharma', or 'eternal faith' (though 'faith', as I explain shortly, is an inadequate translation of 'dharma'). Sanatana is eternal in the sense that it refers to a *dharma* that is old and new at the same time, ever-present and ever-evolving. In Hinduism, there is no difficulty in accepting that some aspects of *dharma* will be rendered irrelevant over the aeons and that other ideas, innovations and reforms will be infused into the faith and rejuvenate it. The essence of *dharma*, however, remains unchanged throughout eternity.

The Hindu concept of time is very different from Western ideas. In Hindu thought, the world has no beginning and no end, but only experiences endless repetitive cycles of time in four *yuga*s (aeons or ages): Satya Yuga, the age of truth, Treta Yuga, Dvapara Yuga and Kali Yuga (the age of destruction and untruth, the one in which we are all living now). Each Kali Yuga ends with a great flood (*pralaya*) that destroys the world, only to start afresh with a new Satya Yuga. Some Hindus argue that Vaishnavites and Shaivites differ in their perception of time; after all, Vishnu is reincarnated in various *avatar*s, while Shiva simply 'is'. Vaishnavites, in this reading, are constantly changing through time, while Shaivites are focused on the annihilation of the self. Though the distinction is interesting, both sets of Hindus relate to time very differently from followers of other faiths, whose temporal existence on this earth culminates, after death, in paradise or hellfire.

I mentioned earlier that *dharma* is often translated as faith, and that this is an inadequate translation. The concept of *dharma* is much broader, embracing an entire system of social ethics covering law-abiding conduct. Indeed, in an afterword to *The Great Indian Novel* in 1989, I listed a whole series of meanings that have been ascribed to the term '*dharma'*, an untranslatable Sanskrit word that is, nonetheless, breezily defined as an unitalicised entry in many an English dictionary. (The *Chambers Twentieth-Century Dictionary*, for example, defines it as 'the righteousness that underlies the law'.) A passable effort, to be sure, but no one-word translation in English ('faith', 'religion', 'law'), can convey